

MODULE 28 / 40

American Robin

*Turdus migratorius***QUICK STATS**

Length	7.9 – 11.0 in (20 – 28 cm)
Wingspan	12.2 – 15.8 in (31 – 40 cm)
Weight	2.7 – 3.0 oz (77 – 85 g)
Lifespan	Up to 14 years (avg. 2 in wild)

PRESENTATION

The American Robin is perhaps the most universally recognized bird in North America — a large, familiar thrush whose brick-red breast, dark back, yellow bill, and bold white eye ring are known to virtually every North American from childhood. It is the state bird of Connecticut, Michigan, and Wisconsin, and its cheerful caroling song — a rich, flowing "cheerily, cheer up, cheer up, cheerily, cheer up" — is one of the quintessential sounds of spring. The American Robin is often cited as the first sign of spring, though many populations actually winter in the northern states, gathering in large nomadic flocks that feed on berries.

HABITAT & RANGE

The American Robin breeds across virtually all of North America, from Alaska and northern Canada south through Mexico. It is one of the most widespread and abundant birds on the continent. It inhabits an extraordinary range of environments: forest edges, open woodlands, suburban lawns, parks, golf courses, farmland, alpine meadows, and tundra edges. It is a year-round resident in most of the United States, though northern populations are partially migratory. In winter, flocks gather wherever fruiting trees are abundant.

DIET & FEEDING

- Earthworms — pulled from lawns, the iconic foraging image
- Wild berries: holly, crabapple, mountain ash, juniper, dogwood
- Insects and larvae during the breeding season
- Small fruits: cherry, grape, serviceberry, hackberry
- Occasionally visits platform feeders for mealworms or fruit
- Robins rarely use seed feeders — berries and worms are essential

BEHAVIOR & SOCIAL LIFE

American Robins are highly territorial during the breeding season but become intensely gregarious in winter, gathering in nomadic flocks of hundreds to thousands of birds that roam the landscape in search of fruiting trees. Their famous earthworm-hunting behavior — running a few steps, stopping abruptly, cocking the head, then plunging the bill into the ground — is based primarily on sight, not sound, despite popular belief. Robins are among the earliest morning singers, beginning their caroling well before dawn — a behavior driven by the low light levels at which their large eyes can detect prey before most other birds can forage.

NESTING & BREEDING

The American Robin builds one of the most recognizable nests in North America — a robust cup of grasses and mud, often placed on a building ledge, porch light, or tree branch 5–25 feet above the ground. The mud forms a hard, durable outer cup. Clutches of 3–5 vivid blue eggs ("robin's egg blue") are incubated by the female for 12–14 days. Both parents feed the nestlings, which fledge at 14–16 days. Pairs raise 2–3 broods per season, reusing or building new nests.

SONG & COMMUNICATION

The American Robin's song is a rich, flowing carol of rising and falling phrases — "cheerily, cheer up, cheer up, cheerily, cheer up" — delivered in long, continuous bouts from a treetop. It is one of the first bird songs heard at dawn and often one of the last at dusk. The call is a sharp "tut-tut-tut" or "whinny" alarm, instantly recognizable once learned. Both sexes produce calls, but only males deliver the full caroling song.

CONSERVATION STATUS

IUCN Red List:	Least Concern	Population trend:	Stable
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The American Robin population is estimated at 300 million individuals — one of the most abundant birds in North America — and is broadly stable. It has benefited greatly from the spread of suburban lawns and ornamental berry trees. Pesticide use on lawns poses a significant risk, as robins consume large quantities of earthworms that accumulate chemical residues. Avoiding lawn pesticides is one of the most meaningful steps a homeowner can take for robins.

FEEDER TIPS

- Plant native fruiting trees: crabapple, hawthorn, holly, and serviceberry
- Offer mealworms in a shallow platform dish — robins will come for them
- Maintain a lawn area with moist soil for earthworm foraging
- A shallow ground-level birdbath is strongly attractive to robins
- Robins nest on ledges and porches — a simple wooden shelf can host a nest

COLORING GUIDE

ZONE	RECOMMENDED COLOR
Head (male)	Dark charcoal-black
Back & wings	Gray-brown
Breast & belly	Rich brick-orange red
Throat	White with dark streaks
Eye ring	Bold white — key field mark
Bill	Yellow-orange, fairly long

COLOR ME!

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